

Capstone Scoping Questions

Day 1 handout. The Week-8 capstone subject is fixed for every quad: **Holocron** (see `holocron-problem-brief.md`). So the question is no longer *what* to build a specification for — it is *how much*. These five questions lock a defensible slice that survives contact with a 4-day build. If 1+ answer is "no," narrow the slice — better now than Wednesday.

The 5 scoping questions

1. **One-sentence problem?** Can you state the Holocron problem you are solving in one sentence an engineer could scope from — not a restatement of the mandate, and not a feature list?
2. **Who is it for first?** Have you named the primary user for release one, and can you defend choosing them over the others in the brief?
3. **Substantive but bounded?** Is the slice rich enough to carry a real specification, yet small enough to fully specify in four days?
4. **Evidence, not invention?** For every claim you plan to make, can you point to a fact in the brief — or flag it honestly as an assumption with an owner?
5. **Shippable in 4 days?** Can you produce the full artifact set (PRD-light → TCD-light + TMD-light → AI Spec → SEP-light + DP-light) by Friday morning?

How to use it

1. **Read the problem brief** end to end as a quad before answering anything.
2. **Walk the 5 questions** honestly. Write the answers down — vague answers here produce a vague capstone.

3. **Draw the scope line.** Name what is in release one and what you are deliberately deferring. The deferral list is as much a deliverable as the inclusion list.
 4. **List the inputs you need** before tomorrow's discovery — which stakeholders you would interview, which facts in the brief you will build on, which open questions you must resolve or route.
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Watch-outs

- **Trying to specify everything.** The brief describes an enterprise platform. A quad that tries to cover every capability produces a thin specification of all of it instead of a strong specification of some of it. Choosing is the skill being assessed.
- **Scoping by feature instead of by outcome.** "We'll do the editing screens" is a feature slice. "A content owner can change published text without an engineer" is an outcome slice — and it tells you which capabilities are actually required.
- **Inventing facts.** The brief gives you real numbers and real constraints. Anything beyond them is an assumption and must be labelled as one, with an owner.
- **Skipping the governance driver.** Compliance review and audit evidence are a stated reason this work exists. A slice that ignores them is answering an easier question than the one you were asked.

Output

A one-sentence problem statement, a named primary user, an explicit in/out scope line for release one, and a list of discovery inputs to gather before Day 2.